Three Mistakes Families Make About the Care Conversation While Everyone Is Well

What each one looks like, why it happens, and the kinder habit that replaces it.

When nothing is wrong, most families handle the subject of future care in the same three ways. None of them comes from a lack of love, and each has a kinder habit to put in its place.

1 Waiting until choices feel rushed

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE “We'll talk about it when we need to.” The subject gets saved for some later day, on the theory that a quiet year is no time to bring it up.

WHY IT HAPPENS It's a hard subject to open, and on an ordinary Tuesday nothing asks you to. AARP's planning guide for families says these conversations are easy to put off because they can be difficult, and adds that you may be surprised to find the other person has been meaning to have the talk, too. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask her while it's only a conversation. The National Institute on Aging says a talk like this is most productive when there is not an emergency. Ask her permission, start with her ordinary days, and let it take more than one sitting. [2]

2 Assuming independence means no conversation is needed

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE “She's fine. She does everything herself.” Both true. So the family concludes there's nothing to discuss, and fills in her wishes from what it thinks it knows.

WHY IT HAPPENS The subject sounds as if it's about needing help, and she doesn't need any. But this conversation isn't about help. It's about what she would want to keep. The Conversation Project observes that we sometimes think others know how we feel when they don't. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Make her independence the subject. Ask what a good day looks like, which routines she'd hate to lose and who she'd want involved, and write down what she says in her words. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly. [4]

3 Making promises about caregiving that relatives cannot keep

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE “Don't worry, we'll always take care of you.” Said with love, at a calm moment, before anyone has asked what it would involve or who would do it.

WHY IT HAPPENS A promise is the warmest thing to offer when nothing is being asked of you. But circumstances move. The National Institute on Aging notes that family members' availability can change over time, and that no one can be expected to do everything. [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Offer what's honest. Ask each of the kids what they could really do, how often, and what it depends on: a job, the distance, their own health. AARP's guide suggests each family member consider what they are prepared and not prepared to do. Write the answers down as they're given, and thank the ones who said less than you hoped. [1]

The one habit behind all three

Ask, and write down what was actually said: her words, each person's honest offer, and the questions nobody can answer yet.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say whether your wife will ever need help, what the family ought to offer, or what anyone should decide. It names three habits, which are the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three habits to trade in, and what goes in their place. When you and your wife are ready, the care interview adds a structured look at her situation, area by area, and keeps what she wants alongside it in a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The points about putting the conversation off, talking when there is no emergency, asking directly and being realistic come from the sources below. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
3. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement), Your Conversation Starter Guide: How to talk about what matters to you and have a say in your health care
4. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.